Yes, the BJP did get a substantial Hindu vote, especially in UP and Bihar (see chapter 5 and appendix 2), but this can be best described as the result of ‘identity plus’ politics. The party had a core Hindutva vote, but to win a national election, it needed a wider base. In a sense, Modi did a Tony Blair. Like the former British prime minister made a struggling Labour party more ‘electable’ by discarding its ideological dogmas and creating ‘New Labour’, Modi, too, reinvented the BJP. This was almost a new, freshly minted BJP—market-friendly, not pushing swadeshi economics. Governance, not religious politics, became its distinctive appeal for those Indians who remained sceptical of the Bajrang Dal–VHP (Vishwa Hindu Parishad) foot soldiers. Of the seventy seats where voter turnout increased by 15 per cent or more, the BJP and its allies won a staggering sixty-seven. Modi’s other great success was in understanding the changing demographics of India—a younger, aspirational society that is easily the most upwardly mobile in the world. Modi likes to see the core of this new India as a ‘neo-middle class’ society which is tiring of state-sponsored welfarism and simply wants market-driven growth As a *Wall Street Journal* article points out, ‘Modi tapped into the frustration of a generation of Indians who climbed out of poverty in the past decade, but who have been prevented from joining the middle classes by slowing growth and a lack of employment.’

Modi has presented himself as India’s first post-liberalization politician (I refer to this in some detail in chapter 8), someone who has sought to combine a certain cultural rootedness with the vaulting desire of millions of Indians to get onto the superhighway to prosperity. He tapped into this yearning for *parivartan* (change), especially by offering himself as a muscular leader in contrast to the weak leadership of Manmohan Singh and the dynastical legacy of Rahul Gandhi. He was aggressive and communicative—qualities that go down well with young Indians in particular. How often did one hear on the campaign trail a young voter saying he would vote for Modi because ‘at last, we will have a prime minister who talks!’ Of the 810 million electorate, first-time voters in the eighteen to twenty-three age group were around 120 million, or almost 15 per cent. The CSDS (Centre for the Study of Developing Societies)-Lokniti